court pronounced in 1978 that the shrine was venerated by both Hindus and Muslims and ordered that status quo be maintained, a decision that was also endorsed by the Karnataka High Court in 1991.[68] The matter took a political turn when the BJP sought to turn Bababudangiri into yet another Ayodhya. While efforts to galvanise more Hindu pilgrims to the shrine began in the early 1990s, the Bajrang Dal and the VHP together organised a pilgrim procession on a noticeably large scale in 1997. The number of pilgrims undertaking the annual journey by foot to the shrine began to swell in size thereafter. In 2002 and 2003, over 20,000 devotees were estimated to have visited the shrine annually in December to observe Datta Jayanti.[69] 'Both issues of the Idgah Maidan and Baba Budangari were not of the same emotive appeal as the Ram Temple. They did not turn into such a test of identity as the Ayodhya dispute did,' says Veeraraghav. But 'they certainly helped the BJP to consolidate its constituency in Karnataka as it made its first political inroads'.[70]

How fundamental is the usage of political Hindutva for the BJP in general? 'It is a by-product [of] whatever we do,' said a senior BJP minister in Karnataka, speaking off-the-record. Hard-line Hindutva leaders, he said, 'don't regret whatever they do. They feel that we do it for our culture, our sentiment and our feelings. The sense of Hindutva is our very strength.' Politics, in his view, was about identity and 'identity is what we will ask about most. If you ask the question, who are we, the answer to that question is most important. Preservation and propagation of our culture is our first and foremost priority. Then comes everything else. As an organisation we can talk about it. People appreciate it. As a government we can't do it.'[71]

A Question of Language: Konkani, Hindi and Why the BJP Made Early Coastal and Urban Inroads

Political movements can provide a push for a political party, but they may not be quite enough. To grow, parties need a critical mass of voters, key social groups on their side and a strong machinery. Since 1991, when it first won four of the state's twenty-eight Lok Sabha seats, the Karnataka BJP has always maintained a vote share in the